A SELF-HELP GUIDEBOOK

The *Wave Passes*

A small book about panic and finding your way back to calm



Anastasiia

psychologist · mind & body

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A letter from *me*



If you are holding this book, you probably already know the feeling: your heart suddenly races, there isn't enough air, and it seems something terrible is about to happen.

I want you to know from the very start: you are okay. A panic attack does not make you weak or “broken”. It is a body that has been under strain for too long and has learned to sound the alarm early.

In this book I have gathered what helps my clients: simply, without complicated terms, with exercises you can do on your own. Read at your own pace. Come back to the pages that resonate.

You are not alone. And calm is a skill you can learn.

With warmth, Anastasiia

What a panic attack *is*

A panic attack is a sudden wave of intense fear that the body lives through very physically. It builds quickly and passes just as surely.

What the body feels

- a racing heart, pressure in the chest
- shortness of breath, hard to inhale
- dizziness, feeling you might faint
- shaking, hot or cold flashes, sweating
- nausea, discomfort in the stomach
- numbness or tingling in hands and feet

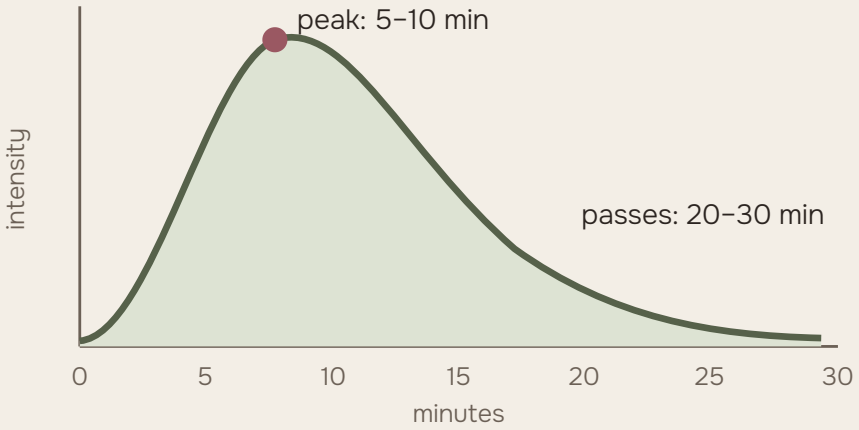
What happens in the mind

- a sense of unreality, as if things are “not real”
- fear of losing control or “going crazy”
- fear of dying, as if it is about to happen right now

> A panic attack is usually described when at least four of these appear at once.

The wave: how an attack *unfolds*

An attack is like a wave. It starts suddenly, peaks after about 5–10 minutes and recedes within 20–30 minutes.



It varies: once every few weeks or months, and in hard periods several times a day. But every wave ends.

> When it hits, remind yourself: “I'm on a wave. It will pass, as the others did.”

Why it is not *dangerous*

A panic attack itself does not kill you or make you go crazy. Thoughts of dying during an attack are the voice of fear, not a forecast.

But first, a doctor

Similar sensations can come from heart, blood vessel, thyroid or neurological conditions. So if this happened for the first time or keeps repeating, see your family doctor. Once your body has been checked, working with panic becomes much easier, because the fear of “what if it's something else” goes away.

Panic or panic disorder?

Strong panic in an extreme situation is a normal reaction. Panic disorder is when attacks repeat without a clear reason and, between them, a person fears the next one. It responds well to help: psychotherapy and, if needed, treatment prescribed by a doctor.

Where panic comes *from*

Almost everyone who has had an attack asks: “Why me?” But looking for someone to blame often only adds anger and shame, and they feed anxiety.

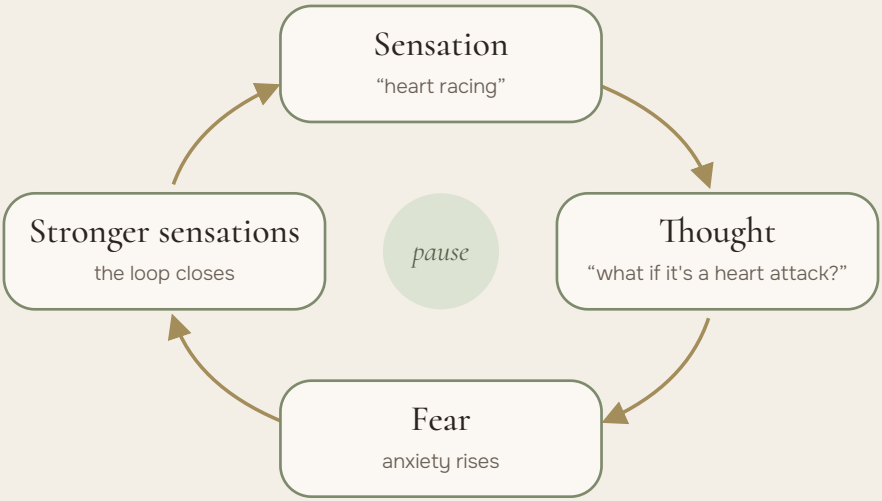
What may play a part

- an inborn sensitivity of the nervous system and high anxiety in the family
- a childhood lacking a sense of safety: losses, illness, addiction of loved ones, war
- big changes and the pressure of adulthood: moving, independent life, responsibility

> “What can I do now” matters more than “why”. That is what the next pages are about.

The panic *loop*

Panic is fuelled not by the sensation itself but by the story we tell about it. You notice your heart beating faster, think “what if it's a heart attack?”, get scared, and the fear makes your heart beat even harder.



This is the main trap: we try to explain the sensation, imagine the worst, and those thoughts create new symptoms.

> The easiest place to break the loop is the first step: notice the sensation and don't add a scary story to it.

What quietly keeps the fear *alive*

We do everything to protect ourselves, and some ways of protecting actually keep the fear alive.

Avoidance

Not going where it “hit” you. Your world slowly shrinks, and all your attention circles around the fear.

“Just in case” rituals

Water, pills, phone, an exit nearby. The relief is temporary, and without the ritual it gets even scarier.

Superstitions

“I don't believe it, but just in case...” When we skip one, anxiety grows.

A “rescuer”

Only going out with a person with whom “it doesn't happen”. This creates an unhealthy dependence on them.

Fighting

Trying to “switch off” panic at any cost. Like the old joke about a man who makes a strange noise to “keep the elephants away” when there are no elephants: energy goes into defending against a danger that isn't there.

Untangling thoughts and *feelings*

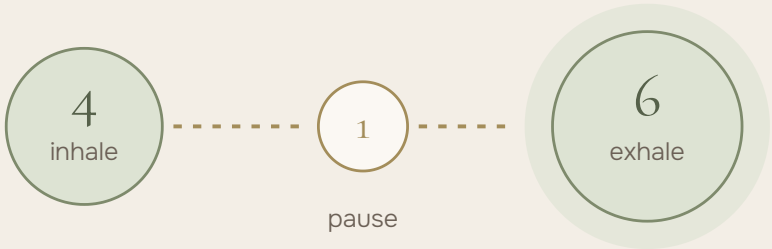
During an attack everything tangles into one knot. Try to lay it out step by step:

1. I notice the sensation: “I feel hot, dizzy, tingling in my arm.”
2. I notice the thought: “It seems like a heart attack.”
3. I notice the emotion: “I'm scared. And I'm angry at myself that it's happening again.”
4. I change my tone: “Yes, it's unpleasant. But I've been through this. I won't blame myself; I'll follow the plan.”
5. I act: I start slow breathing and notice it getting easier. “Ah, that's better.”

> The more often you untangle the knot like this, the faster it becomes a habit.

Anchor *breathing*

During panic we breathe fast and shallow, into the chest. This upsets the balance of gases in the body and causes dizziness and tingling. A slow exhale tells the body: “there is no danger.”



1. Put one hand on your belly and the other on your chest.
2. Breathe out through your mouth, as if with relief, and let your shoulders drop.
3. Slowly breathe in through your nose for 4 counts, gently inflating your belly. Your chest stays almost still.
4. A short pause for 1 count.
5. A long slow exhale through the mouth for 6 counts, as if cooling hot tea.
6. Repeat for a few minutes until your body starts letting go.

> Dizziness or yawning is not dangerous. It's a sign to breathe a little slower. Practise daily when calm: then during an attack your body will remember what to do.

An anchor *word*

This is a short relaxation exercise. Do it sitting or lying down, never while driving.

1. Choose a short, calm word: “quiet”, “forest”, “sleep”.
2. Sit comfortably, breathe out and let your shoulders drop. Breathe with your belly.
3. On each exhale softly say your word, 6–12 times.
4. Tell yourself: “Now I allow myself to relax.” No orders, no effort.
5. Count 10–15 exhales and add a warm phrase: “I will calmly wait for the wave to pass.”
6. Open your eyes, look right and left. Repeat the whole sequence twice more.

> Avoid command phrases like “I must calm down right now.” The body listens to gentleness, not pressure.

A 5-step *plan*

Your task during an attack is not to stop the panic but to ride the wave as gently as possible.

1 · Name it

“I'm having a panic attack. I'm scared, and I'm allowed to feel this. It will pass.”

2 · Stay and observe

You'll want to run. Slowly count to 10: “The urge to run is my body's reaction; there is no real threat.”

3 · Act gently

Anchor breathing. Release your jaw, shoulders, hands. Ask: “What is happening now? What would help me?”

4 · If the wave returns, start again

This is normal. Every wave is one more chance to practise.

5 · It will end

All attacks pass. Your only job is to be kind to yourself while the wave recedes.

Grounding *5-4-3-2-1*

This exercise brings your attention back from anxious thoughts to the present moment through the senses.



5
things you can see. Slowly name them to yourself.

4
touches: feet on the floor, clothes, a surface under your hand, air on your skin.

3
sounds: what is close and what is far.

2
smells. If there are none, recall two favourites.

1
taste: a sip of water or simply the taste in your mouth.

> Anxiety lives in the future (“what if…”). The body is always here and now.

A panic attack *journal*

Write right after an attack or as close to it as you can. In a few weeks you will see what triggers your anxiety and what helps you in particular.

> Fill it in without judging. It isn't an exam; it's your map.

Date, time	Where I was	What my body felt	First thought	Strength 0–10	What helped

When to ask for *help*

Self-help is very useful, but it does not replace a professional. See a psychologist, therapist or doctor if:

- attacks are frequent or getting stronger
- you have started avoiding places, people or activities
- anxiety gets in the way of work, sleep or relationships
- thoughts appear that life isn't worth living

If things feel unbearable right now, or you have thoughts of harming yourself, call 112 (anywhere in Europe) or 7333 (Lifeline Ukraine).

This book is self-help support, not treatment. But every page here was written believing that calm will come back to you.

With warmth, Anastasiia